NATIONAL PEOPLE'S PARTY (NPP)

CM contender: Yumnam Joykumar Singh, 67
Alliance partner: None

STRENGTHS

- Selection of strong candidates
- Campaign for repeal of AFSPA has a connect with voters
- Social media campaign is attracting young voters

CHALLENGES

- Contesting only 40 of 60 seats
- Y. Joykumar Singh's record as DGP may go against the party
- Organisationally not as strong as BJP and Congress



Around a dozen of the BJP candidates this time were with the Congress in the previous election. Several leaders who were denied tickets by the BJP and the Congress have joined the NPP and Janata Dal (United). Representing a party may have its advantages, but victory is often determined by the candidates' equation with the electorate. As Congress-turned-BJP leader Rajkumar Imo Singh tells voters in Sagolband: "The car's brand doesn't matter. If the driver remains the same, then the quality of driving will be the same."

The BJP, one may argue, is in favour going by the rush of ticket-seekers, but those annoyed over being denied a ticket may mar the party's chances. Victory margins in Manipur are usually narrow, with 32,000 being the average electorate size of an assembly seat. "Ultimately, the potential of candidates, irrespective of their party affiliation, will determine the poll results," says Prof. Rajen Singh Laishram, head of the political science department at Manipur University.

Of the 60 assembly seats, with a total electorate of 1.9 million, 40 are in the valley areas spanning six districts—Imphal East, Imphal West, Thoubal, Bishnupur, Kakching and Kangpokpi. The other 20 seats are spread over the remaining 10 districts. The valley districts, dominated by the Meitei community, account for just over 11 per cent of the geographical area but 57 per cent of the state's 2.8 million people (Census 2011). The remaining population lives in the hill districts, dominated by the Naga and Kuki tribes. Ethnic tension between the Meiteis and the Nagas/Kukis also dictates politics in the state. Discontent in every region has given rise to insurgent groups based on ethnicity.

But Biren Singh, a Meitei, claims these divisions are a thing of the past. He is the first state chief minister in 15 years to have got a red carpet welcome from Nagas in Ukhrul. The district has not only given Manipur two Naga CMs—Yangmaso Shazia and Rishang Keishing—but is home to Thuingaleng Muivah, general secretary of the NSCN(IM) insurgent group. Visits to Ukhrul by former chief minister Okram Ibobi Singh during the previous Congress regime had seen boycotts, shutdowns and violence.

In contrast, Biren Singh, a former protégé of Ibobi Singh, has addressed crowds in Ukhrul without bullet-proof cover. The BJP credits this changed equation between the state government and the Nagas to the CM's 'Go to Hills' outreach aimed at delivering government welfare to people's doorsteps in the tribal-dominated hills. There were other initiatives too, such as interaction with civil society groups, sensitising the police to be people friendly and opening channels with the militant groups.



BIREN SINGH'S REPORT CARD

The NPF, which is restricted to the Naga-dominated hill areas and won four seats in 2017, is not impressed by the BJP's claims. "The Biren Singh government's acceptability is due to the NPF being a constituent. Our party ensured that the government was sensitive to the concerns of Nagas," says Ram Muivah, the NPF candidate from Ukhrul, where the party came third in 2017. The former IAS officer says Ukhrul still "looks like a slum", with poor roads, drainage and other infrastructure. For the record, it takes three hours to cover the 80 km distance by road between Imphal and Ukhrul. For all-round development of the hill districts, the NPF wants effective implementation of Article 371(C) of the Constitution (which pertains to the special provision for Manipur), including a separate budget and directorate for the region. Both the BJP and NPF claim their tally will go up in the hills—from five and four respectively last time.

Biren Singh concedes "there's lots to do" in terms of developing the hills and the valley. "We started out well, but the pandemic constrained us financially and affected development projects," reasons Singh. He lists out his achievements—highways connecting Imphal to border towns, Ima markets (run exclusively by women), tap water supply to 64 per cent of the population (it was 5.7 per